



Russia's natural wealth

Gas pipelines such as this one stretch from Siberia to Europe. In 2006 Russia supplied one-third of Europe's oil and 40 percent of its gas. Russia has occasionally used these resources for political ends, cutting off supplies to Georgia and Ukraine.

1939 Nazi-Soviet Pact gives USSR the Baltic states, eastern Poland, and Bessarabia.

1941 Germany attacks the USSR and its armies advance rapidly, catching Stalin unprepared.

1943 Great Soviet victory at Stalingrad halts the Germans, as its besieged army surrenders.

1944–45 Soviet offensive penetrates the Balkans and crosses Germany to Berlin.

1945 Germany is defeated. Under the Yalta and Potsdam agreements between the USSR, US, and UK, eastern and most of southeastern Europe fall within the Soviet zone of influence.

1947 Cold War begins with the US and its Western allies. Stalin, fearing the penetration of Western capitalist values, persecutes returning soldiers.

1953 Stalin dies and is eventually replaced by Nikita Khrushchev.

1956 Khrushchev makes a "secret speech" at the Twentieth Party Congress

denouncing the cult of Stalin. Reforms remove the worst excesses of Stalinist power and repression.

1957 USSR launches *Sputnik I*, the first artificial satellite in space.

1961 Yuri Gagarin is first man in space.

1962 Cuban missile crisis brings the world close to nuclear war. Khrushchev backs down and does not send missiles.

1964 Khrushchev is ousted in a coup and replaced by Leonid Brezhnev, who ushers in a period of economic stagnation and political reaction.

1975 Helsinki Final Act confirms European frontiers as at the end of World War II.

1979 Soviet troops enter Afghanistan in support of the communist government.

1982 Brezhnev dies, and is followed by two elderly successors, Andropov and Chernenko, who both die in office.

1985 Mikhail Gorbachev comes to power and begins the process of perestroika, "restructuring" the economy. The first of three US–USSR summits results in arms reduction treaties. Nationalist conflicts surface in the republics.

1988 Law of Cooperatives permits limited private ownership of businesses.

1990 Gorbachev becomes Soviet president. There is the first part-elected parliament.

1991 Boris Yeltsin is elected president of Russia. Yeltsin and Muscovites resist a hardline communist coup against Gorbachev, who bans the Communist Party. As Russia and the other republics leave the USSR and set up the Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS), the USSR collapses.

1992 The country moves rapidly from communism to free-market capitalism involving a series of cut-rate privatizations of state-owned companies. Russia takes up the seat of the former USSR on the UN Security Council.

1993 Yeltsin decrees the dissolution of Supreme Soviet and uses force to disband parliament. Elections return conservative state Duma (parliament).

1994–96 Russian military offensive against Chechnya.

1995 Communists win parliamentary elections.

1996 Yeltsin is reelected despite strong communist challenge.

1998 Economic turmoil forces devaluation of the ruble. There is severe recession and rampant inflation.

1998–99 Yeltsin repeatedly changes prime ministers in a succession of crises.

1999 Parliamentary elections: Yeltsin resigns and the prime minister, Vladimir Putin, becomes acting president.

1999–2000 Terrorist violence blamed on Islamic separatists in Dagestan and Chechnya. In a renewed military offensive against Chechnya, the Chechen capital Grozny falls to Russian forces.

2000 Putin wins presidential election and consolidates power. He attacks the "oligarchs" who made fortunes in the privatizations of former state enterprises. The Russian economy begins to improve.

2000 Kursk nuclear submarine sinks in the Barents Sea with loss of the entire 118-man crew.

2001 Mergers make Putin's United Russia Party the largest grouping in parliament.

2002 Russia reaches agreement with US on strategic nuclear weapons reduction. Russia and NATO establish a council to cooperate on countering terrorism.

2002 Chechen separatists storm a Moscow theater and seize hostages: 128 hostages are killed during the rescue. Two years later, hundreds of children die in the Beslan school massacre.

2004 Putin is reelected president.

2006 Russia cuts gas supplies to Ukraine over prices. The Kremlin says this is an economic decision, while Kiev claims

political motives. Relations with Georgia deteriorate after Russian officers are arrested on suspicion of spying.

2006 Campaigning journalist Anna Politkovskaya is murdered.

2007 Former president Boris Yeltsin dies of heart failure.

2007 President Putin's United Russia party wins a landslide election victory.

2008 Dimitri Medvedev wins presidential election. Vladimir Putin becomes prime minister. Tensions with Georgia over the separatist South Ossetia region lead to war. Russian forces pull back from positions in Georgia, but retain a strong presence in South Ossetia. Russia threatens to deploy missiles in its Kaliningrad enclave in response to US intentions to establish a missile shield in Europe.

2010 Heatwave devastates the Russian wheat crop. Suicide bomb kills 39 on the Moscow subway.

«296–97 The First Global Conflict
«376–77 The Russian Revolution
«406–07 The Cold War
«444–45 War in Afghanistan
«446–47 Perestroika

Ukraine



The second-largest country in Europe after Russia, Ukraine means "on the border."

800s CE Varangian Vikings establish themselves in Kiev and unite the Slavs in the powerful Kievan Rus.



Ukrainian famine

This starving Ukrainian peasant was photographed around 1933. Stalin's decision to requisition all grain for export led to the worst man-made famine in history. At least seven million died of hunger.

DECISIVE MOMENT

CHECHNYA DECLARES INDEPENDENCE, 1991



On November 1, 1991, Chechnya, a Soviet republic, declared its independence as the USSR collapsed. The Chechens of the northern Caucasus have a proud history as an independent people, but were no match for the Russian army that invaded the country in 1994 and smashed the capital, Grozny (left).

A peace agreement was signed in August 1996. Fighting resumed in 1999 and has continued ever since, with great brutality from the Russian forces, who now identify the Chechens as Muslim terrorists rather than as a people seeking to rule themselves.